

Khan plays Surinder Sahni, a clerk who works for Punjab Power and whose alter ego's height of trendiness involves sharing golgappas with the one he loves and getting wet in the rain on a motorbike. Indeed, the Indian Everyman became a global export. In *Slumdog Millionaire*, the best film made on contemporary India, oddly enough by a Scottish-born director with English and American money, Jamal Malik played a

call centre *chaiwala* who wins the Rs 2-crore prize on *Who Wants to be a Millionaire* by parlaying the knowledge he has learnt in a life spent on the streets.

Good evening, Namas-kar, Sat Sri Akal, Aadaab. In a time of economic meltdown and terror hitting home, as Jamal would say, this was our destiny. Joe the Plumber may not have won John McCain the American elections but his Indian counterpart certainly made a permanent place for him-

self on the Indian screens, allowing us to project ourselves on the wide screen in all our frailties. The men who lit up our lives this year were people like us. There was Rats, Jai Singh Rathore of youthful hit, *Jaane Tu... Ya Jaane Na*, an impoverished princeling who ran away from college fights and shared breakfast duty with his single mother. Here was Raj Sharma, who spent an entire movie finding the love of his life—in the young girl who could drive a taxi by night and study for an MBA by day in *Bachna Ae Haseeno*. For all these men, the goal was personal redemption. If the Punjab Power clerk was trying to convince his wife of his inner geek god, then for Singhania, the journey was to recover his past, and most importantly, his memories of it. These were bite-sized hopes, the kind cherished by those usually unthinkingly considered the marching morons, those men and women who watch helplessly as Maximum City landmarks are reduced to rubble and a lifetime of savings is wiped out in the flash of a Dalal Street instant.

It took Hollywood years to catch up with the post-9/11 reality. A nation in mourning learnt to be entertained again but with a difference. Its superheroes became dark knights, its independent film movement tried a little sunshine and its franchise movies were transformed into even noisier and dumber spectacles. How did Bollywood become so prescient? What clairvoyance caused Neeraj Pandey to make the disturbing *A Wednesday*, where a common man holds the Mumbai Police to ransom, threaten-

ing that he has left bombs lying waiting to be detonated across the city if his demand for four terrorists is not met? What great grasp on the future caused Nishikant Kamat to make *Mumbai Meri Jaan*, in which intertwined lives learn to cope with the trauma of facing the aftermath of July 2006 bomb blasts? What depths of horror caused Raj Kumar Gupta to make *Aamir*, the tale of an England-returned doctor who is urged to place a bomb on a bus if he wants to fight for his "quam" and show fealty to his family?

What utter fearlessness caused Ram Gopal Varma to underscore the petty politics that created a Raj Thackeray in *Sarkar Raj*? And what right timing got Shyam Benegal to compose a love letter to India's forgotten villages, the suppliers of its *White Tiger* drivers and its *Slumdog chaiwalas*, in *Welcome to Sajjanpur*?

Could it just be that the 59 hours in Mumbai beginning November 26 were just a gory repeat of what has passed before? It could be 2001 when terrorists attacked Parliament. It could be 2004 when we turfed out a government that promised us India was shining but didn't heed the incipient warning of overspending, over-indulging and over-consuming.

Or it could be the inexorable pull of our history, warning of communal conflagration from the time of Akbar and Jodha, both sexed up in Ashutosh Gowariker's retouched version as the perfectly blended couple for a rainbow nation. But then when the year

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